The Ballad of Isla's Shadow

The Adventure Continues

1. Introduction

A remote frontier town called Driftmoor is nestled south of the jagged cliffs of the Obelisk Reach. The region is known for its mysterious ancient ruins and strange phenomena tied to an ancient, shattered obelisk that looms over the land. Driftmoor has a population of about 500; mostly humans, halflings, and a few dwarves and elves. The town has several modest stone and timber buildings with various shops, a tavern, a rooming house, a church, and the mayor's hall. Its small harbor is sheltered by rocky outcroppings. Wooden piers and fishing boats dominate the harbor scene, with ramshackle homes belonging to the fisherfolk. The waters are teeming with fish, but the occasional shadowy form beneath the surface unnerves the locals. A mile or two upriver are a mill and scattered farms growing hardy grains, root vegetables, and some grazing livestock. Farmers often transport their goods downstream to the harbor by raft.

You've arrived in Driftmoor via many different paths over the last few days. By chance, you've all arrived at the Broken Lantern tavern on the same evening to hear their featured entertainer, Kaelin Brightspark, a bard of some repute, perform the story of the night she and the original adventures rescued baby Isla, now two years in the past.

2. The Broken Lantern

On the stage, Kaelin introduces herself and strums her lute while she banters with the audience for a moment and then begins to sing: *The Cry Beyond the Greywater*

I sang beneath the Lantern's flame
While cups and voices rang,
Till Gregan burst in through the door
And silenced what I sang.
"They've taken her! My child!"
He cried into the room,
And every soul went rushing out
Into the gathering gloom.

Poor Mara stood with torn-up clothes
And claw marks on her skin,
While Tessa clutched her wounded side
And tried to hold tears in.
Down through the darkened street we saw
Shapes fleeing through the night,
So I raised my hand and marked them all
In blue and ghostly light.

Run, run, to the Greywater,
Don't let them reach the trees;
We heard a baby crying there
Upon the midnight breeze.
Two fell beneath us at the bridge,
But still they stole away—
And Isla's cries grew faint and dim
Beyond the road that day.

She ends her song, waits for some applause and continues to speak:

At this point, the mayor arrived and offered a substantial reward to those who would rescue baby Isla. So, we formed up a search party. **Elyssa Moonglow**, the local scholar, arrived and told us a story about the Obelisk on a hill by the sea way to the north through the forest. A daemon, **The Queen of Chains** was entombed there ages ago by a cabal of sorcerers. Recently, the seals had weakened, the obelisk had shattered and **Shadowbeasts** had emerged from the caverns to make way for her return. Since then, the town of Driftmoor had been plagued by bizarre events—shadows that move of their own accord, livestock disappearing, and strange symbols appearing in fields overnight. Elyssa said she could help us in our quest and loaned us some magical items to help us in our mission. She urged us to visit Duskcloak's Curios to see if he had any items we could use too. **Kalem Duskcloak** was an odd sort, a keeper of many odd things in his shop. After some negotiation, he agreed to help us with some useful items too, but for a price: a share of our reward if we returned.

Thus, provisioned and armed, we decided to follow the trail immediately while it was still warm and we ventured into the Mistwood Forest using a magical lamp Kalem had provided. We followed the trail through the forest with Aeliana's pet squirrel going ahead in the trees to warn us of danger. By dawn we had reached a round glade in the forest that was very unusual.

She breaks into a song again as she plays her lute: The Fey Glade

Beyond the fog, beneath the boughs,
Where Forest shadows fade,
We found a light both warm and clean
Upon a hidden glade.
The grass shone green as emerald fire,
Strange flowers crowned the ground,
And sweetness drifted through the air
Without a name or sound.

When evening gathered in the leaves
And daylight slipped away,
A thousand colors stirred like sparks
Where moonlit shadows lay.
And in the center, still and round,
A shining pool was cast;
I bent above its trembling light
And saw my buried past.

Oh, carry me back to the Fey Glade,
Where the stars bloom under the trees,
Where yesterday sleeps in a silver pool
And tomorrow rides on the breeze.
I could have dreamed there forevermore,
I would have willingly stayed—
But a faithful hand drew me home again
From the heart of the Fey Glade.
Beyond the fog, beneath the boughs,
Where mortal footsteps fade,

Suddenly her voice changes into a raspy, unnatural voice:

The child bears the lock,
the singer bears the key,
and the pool remembers
what never came to be.

The last chord dies in her fingers. Kaelin stares down at her instrument, visibly shaken. She remembers the rescue clearly; she's never heard these words before. At that moment:

- *At once, every flame in the Broken Lantern turns shimmering violet.*
- *Two listeners glimpse Isla beside the Fey Pool—not as an infant, but as a young woman, watching them through the silver light.*
- *Another sees the shattered Obelisk—and behind it, the Queen of Chains straining against her bonds as they begin to break.*
- *At the edge of the crowd, a rough-looking man rises abruptly and hurries from the tavern.*
- *Then the flames return to gold.*

3. After the Disruption

Everything's a confusing mess in the Broken Lantern. People running out, clustering around Kaelin, talking among themselves. What does the party do now? The party has several strong options immediately after the performance. Ideally, each reveals a different piece of the mystery, while delay allows Jareth or the cult to act.

1. Chase the stranger

Jareth is still close enough to catch, but he knows Driftmoor's alleys and expects pursuit.

If caught, he avoids combat unless cornered. He might surrender when someone mentions Isla or display the broken black chain he carries.

What the party can learn immediately:

- He was Brother Jareth, the faltering cultist at the altar.
- The ritual was interrupted, not wholly undone.
- He recognized Raleth's cadence inside Kaelin's song.
- The black chain grew warm when the flames turned violet.
- Isla remains connected to the Queen.
- Someone else from the cult may also have witnessed the manifestation.

Complication: Jareth assumes the party may kill him and initially lies about his identity.

Best hook:

"If the child still lives, don't follow me. Go to her."

2. Protect Isla

The most urgent defensive choice is to reach the Haverstead home before anyone else does.

There they might find:

- Isla awake despite the late hour, quietly humming Kaelin's melody.
- A faint incomplete sigil visible on her skin in violet light.
- Drawings of the Fey Pool, though she has never visited it.
- Frost or violet candlelight around her room.
- Evidence that someone has recently watched the house.
- A black chain link left at a window or threshold.
- Isla describing "the tall lady who cannot come inside yet."

This confirms that the tavern event was not confined to Kaelin.

Complication: Gregan and Mara may resist reopening the horror of the kidnapping, especially if the party explains that Isla remains part of the ritual.

3. Question the vision-struck witnesses

The three witnesses saw complementary fragments. Interviewing them separately prevents their memories from contaminating one another.

The two who saw older Isla might disagree in revealing ways:

- One saw her as guardian of the Pool, wearing flowers and silver.
- The other saw her trapped beside it, unable to cross the water's edge.

The witness who saw the Queen might recall:

- Chains breaking in time with Kaelin's melody.
- An incomplete sigil appearing beneath Isla.
- Someone standing beside the Obelisk—possibly Jareth, Raleth, or Kaelin.
- The Queen reaching through Isla's shadow rather than emerging from the stone.

Complication: the visions continue in dreams, making the witnesses targets or unwilling oracles.

4. Examine Kaelin

Kaelin may still carry a detectable magical residue.

Possible findings:

- Her voice briefly produces two tones at once.
- The strings of her instrument resonate when "lock," "key," or "pool" is spoken.
- The final four lines appear in her handwriting inside her songbook.
- She remembers an image from the Pool that she previously forgot: Isla at the altar.
- Magical examination reveals both fey divination and the Queen's necrotic influence.
- She cannot willingly sing the strange verse—but her reflection silently mouths it.

A particularly good result is that Kaelin remembers the melody but not the words. The dangerous component may require both.

5. Secure the tavern

The manifestation may have left physical evidence.

Searching the Broken Lantern could reveal:

- One violet flame that refuses to return to gold.
- Frost beneath Jareth's chair.
- A burned chain-shaped mark on the floor.
- An Obelisk fragment carried unknowingly by another patron.
- A symbol scratched beneath Jareth's table.

- Someone who heard a second voice singing beneath Kaelin.
- A patron who vanished during the confusion.

This is the safest option, but it gives Jareth time to escape and any threat time to reach Isla.

6. Consult a magical authority

The party may seek a priest, mage, historian, or fey expert.

Each specialist interprets the event differently:

- **A priest:** Isla carries an incomplete sacramental binding.
- **An arcanist:** Kaelin and Isla are linked endpoints in a dormant spell.
- **A fey scholar:** The Pool does not predict futures; it preserves futures that reality discarded.
- **An Obelisk researcher:** Violet fire indicates resonance between incompatible magical systems.
- **A bardic expert:** The four lines are structured like a ritual response, not a verse.

The most valuable discovery: the song can probably turn the “key” in either direction, depending on how its unresolved cadence is completed.

Complication: the expert may inform an institution that decides Isla and Kaelin are too dangerous to remain free.

7. Return to the ritual site

The altar may reveal what the party missed during the rescue.

They could discover:

- The sigil beneath Isla was left incomplete.
- One section resembles musical notation when viewed from above.
- Jareth deliberately omitted or mispronounced part of the chant.
- Raleth’s black-fire dagger is missing.
- The Shadowbeast’s tendril left a permanent channel between altar and Obelisk.
- One spectral chain remains attached not to the stone, but points toward Driftmoor—or Isla.
- Fresh incense proves someone has returned recently.

Complication: the site is active again, and the Queen can communicate more clearly there.

8. Return to the Fey Pool

This is the most revelatory and potentially most dangerous option.

At the Pool, Kaelin might see:

- The ritual as it would have concluded.
- Older Isla waiting on the opposite bank.
- A future where the Queen is freed.
- A future where Isla replaces the Queen within the prison.
- Jareth kneeling beside the Pool years earlier or later.
- The missing counter-melody needed to close the ritual.

The Pool may answer only through reflections, possible futures, or exchanged memories. It might demand that Kaelin surrender one cherished future to learn how to save Isla.
Complication: singing near the Pool could make an unrealized future temporarily real.

4. Elyssa's Cottage

Elyssa Moonglow lives alone in a simple stone building with slate roof and ivy up the walls on a low hill overlooking the Greywater River. A small chimney emits thin smoke — the fire in her study is almost never out. The front path is lined with overgrown lavender and rosemary. A side herb garden, less well-kept than her work inside. A weathered sign reads "E. Moonglow – Researcher" in Elvish script. Elyssa is a tall, elegant. Silver hair in a loose braid. Piercing blue eyes. Simple practical robes often stained with ink or dust. Hands always slightly smudged.

Elyssa unrolls an ancient parchment, revealing sketches of an enormous stone obelisk wrapped in ethereal chains, arcane symbols etched along its surface. She explains that the obelisk was never just a monument—it was a prison. Long ago, a cabal of sorcerers and holy warriors sealed a demon known as the **Queen of Chains** beneath it, binding her within the stones with wards of divine light and ancient sigils.

But the seals have weakened, the obelisk has shattered and the Shadowbeasts are her first agents—creatures of pure nightmare, clawing their way into reality to prepare for their Queen's return.

- The Queen needed a vessel to fully manifest—a mortal to anchor her spirit in the world.
- The stolen infant was part of the final ritual to break the chains.
- If the Queen is reborn, not even Driftmoor will be left standing
- The adventurers disrupted the ritual and rescued Isla so the Queen is still in chains
- Isla may still have a role in this. The line "the child bears the lock" is a crucial indication
- Does Isla have any marks on her or memories she could share?

The Need for Magical Artifacts

Recognizing the danger of the cult and the Queen's impending release, Elyssa Moonglow agrees to lend the party a few magical items—but she makes it clear that these are not gifts. They must be returned once the crisis is over, or she will seek them out personally.

As she hands over the items, she says:
"*This is not just your fight. These artifacts carry the wisdom of those who came before us. Use them well… and do not make me regret this trust*."

1. The Sunlight Brand (Magical Weapon – Loaned to a Frontline Fighter)
   - Item Type: Magical Longsword (or Battleaxe if Thorgrim wields it)
   - Appearance: A silver-forged weapon with a faint golden shimmer running along its edge. The hilt is inlaid with runes of radiant protection.
   - Effects:
     - +1 to Attack and Damage Rolls.
     - Deals an extra 1d4 Radiant Damage to fiends, undead, and shadow creatures.
     - Light in the Dark: The weapon glows like a torch when within 30 feet of a fiend or undead, revealing hidden creatures.
   - How It Helps: The extra radiant damage and revealing glow are direct counters to the Shadowbeasts and cultists.
2. Aegis of the First Ward (Protective Amulet – Loaned to a Spellcaster or Support Role)
   - Item Type: Magical Amulet
   - Appearance: A silver pendant in the shape of a broken chain, faintly pulsing with warmth.
   - Effects:
     - Once per long rest, the wearer can resist a possession or mind control attempt (Advantage on saving throws against such effects).

    - If reduced to 0 HP, the amulet shatters instead, restoring the wearer to 1 HP instead of falling unconscious.
- How It Helps:
    - Prevents possession or mental influence from the Queen's whispers.
    - Offers a second chance for a party member who might otherwise die in battle.

3. Moonglow's Binding Salts (1-Time Use – Given to a Tactician or Resourceful Player)
    - Item Type: Alchemical Tool
    - Appearance: A small leather pouch filled with shimmering white powder, glowing faintly under moonlight.
    - Effects:
        - Throwing the salts (Action, 10 ft range) interrupts any ongoing dark magic or summoning ritual in a 10-foot radius.
        - Any creature tethered to an extraplanar entity (like a cultist linked to the Queen) takes 2d6 radiant damage and must make a DC 12 Constitution save or be stunned for 1 round.
        - Can weaken chains of dark influence, such as cutting the tether between Isla and the Queen's ritual.
    - How It Helps:
        - This can be a clutch move to halt the Queen's summoning mid-fight or disable the cultists momentarily.
        - Can free Isla safely, preventing her from becoming the Queen's vessel.

Elyssa's Warning

"*I am giving you these because I believe in you… but power is a dangerous thing. Do not let it corrupt you, as it did those who came before."*

She then looks each adventurer in the eye, making sure they understand the responsibility they now bear.
How This Helps Balance the Final Fight

- Radiant Damage from the **Sunlight Brand** helps against Shadowbeasts and Raleth's necrotic magic.
- The **Amulet** prevents mind control/possession—important for resisting the Queen's influence.
- The **Binding Salts** can be used tactically to interrupt the ritual or weaken the cultists.

To stop the Queen, brute force will not be enough. The party is still not strong enough to defeat her without stronger magic. **Elyssa** says that **Kalem Dustcloak**, the town's shadiest merchant of artifacts and curios, may have something that could restore the seals—or at least weaken the Queen's influence. However, Kalem never gives anything for free.
The party will need to:

- Negotiate with Kalem Dustcloak – He may have a chain-link relic or fragments of the original sealing runes, but what price will he demand?
- Track Isla's captor – Whether now or at dawn, they must follow the trail before it vanishes.
- Prepare for the Queen's Next Move – Even if they save Isla, the obelisk's seals are failing. How much time do they truly have before the Queen emerges?

More roleplay discussion to visit Kalem and/or determine next moves

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5. Kalem Dustcloak's Artifacts for Sale

Kalem Dustcloak sits in the shadowy corner of his cluttered shop, fingers steepled as he watches the adventurers with a knowing smirk. Kelem is a wiry, 47-year-old male half-elf with dark hair pulled into a messy ponytail and sharp, calculating eyes that always seem to be appraising everything around him. He wears a

patched, hooded cloak that he never seems to remove, even indoors. He's charming but evasive. Kelem is quick with a smile and a quip but never looks you in the eye.
His establishment, a dimly lit curiosity shop filled with trinkets and forgotten relics, hums with an air of mystery. His display cases offer sever items that might be of interest:

- Shadowbeast Claw Necklace — 15 gp (+2 Intimidation when worn)
- Bone Dice Set — 2 gp (useful for bluffing or cheating)
- Silent Grease — 20 gp/vial (silences a 5-foot area when applied)
- Weighted Dice — 5 gp (advantage on Sleight of Hand to cheat at dice)
- Obsidian Mirror — 25 gp (peek around corners or signal in dim light)
- Pouch of Glowing Powder — 10 gp (clings to surfaces; dim light for 1 hour)
- Iron False Key — 5 gp (advantage on Thieves' Tools to jam locks)
- Traveler's Cloak — 8 gp (weather protection and hidden compartment)
- Smoke Bomb — 15 gp (10-foot smoke cloud for 1 minute)
- Boot Blades — 20 gp (concealed 1d4 piercing weapon; finesse, light)
- Weighted Net — 15 gp (+2 to attack rolls when thrown)
- Obelisk Fragment Replica — 50 gp (convincing fake)

In his private quarters, he has the following more arcane items:

The Lantern of Revealing (400 GP)

- Description: A brass lantern with an intricately wrought handle, its glass panels faintly etched with runes that shimmer when the flame is lit.
- Properties: When lit, the Lantern of Revealing casts bright light for 30 feet and dim light for an additional 30 feet. Any invisible creatures or objects within its light are revealed for what they truly are.
- How It Helps: Shadowbeasts rely on darkness and concealment—this lantern will expose them, making them easier to fight and track.

The Unfinished Link (250 GP)

- Description: A heavy link of black iron, broken cleanly through one side. Its surface bears tiny sigils that seem to rearrange whenever it is not being watched.
- Properties: When held near someone or something touched by the Queen’s ritual, the broken ends pull toward one another. The attraction grows stronger as the ritual connection becomes more active.
- It could:
    - Point toward Isla, Kaelin, Jareth, the ritual dagger, or the Obelisk.
    - Grow painfully cold when the Queen is observing through a marked person.
    - Momentarily complete itself when the strange verse is sung.
    - Reveal which way the “key” is turning: its sigils glow violet when strengthening the prison and black when weakening it.
- Cost or danger: Each use allows the Queen to sense the bearer’s approximate location. If the link ever closes completely, something else may break open.
- Kalem’s complication: He acquired it from a frightened man matching Jareth’s description, who sold it years ago and demanded that Kalem melt it down. Kalem discovered that it would not melt

The Mirror of Roads Unwalked (1,200 GP)

- Description: A small oval hand mirror made from silver-black glass. It reflects the viewer normally until moonlight, violet flame, or fey light touches its surface.
- Properties: The mirror shows a nearby unrealized possibility rather than the present moment. The mirror is particularly responsive near the Fey Pool because both preserve “what never came to be. Used carefully, it might reveal:
    - Older Isla standing where the infant once lay upon the altar.
    - Kaelin completing the ritual song.
    - Jareth choosing to flee before the ritual began.
    - A hidden route someone could have taken.
    - What the ritual chamber would look like if the Queen escaped.

    - The person who most recently handled an Obelisk fragment.
- What Kalem says: “Useful for seeing what might have happened. Less useful for sleeping afterward.”
- Cost or danger**:** The mirror never identifies whether it shows a prevented past, a possible future, or a deliberate temptation. After each use, the viewer temporarily remembers the reflected event as though it truly happened. Repeated use might cause a character to distrust genuine memories—or allow an unrealized version of someone to notice the viewer.
- Kalem’s complication: One evening, the mirror showed Kalem being murdered by a customer. He refuses to say which customer.

The Hushglass Bell (650 GP)

- Description: A thumb-sized bell made from smoky translucent crystal. It has no clapper and makes no audible sound when shaken.
- What Kalem says: “Ring it when something speaks without using its own voice.”
- What it does: When rung near possession, magical compulsion, telepathic influence, or a voice transmitted through another creature, all listeners experience a brief supernatural silence. During that silence, the intruding presence becomes perceptible. If used while Kaelin’s voice changes, the party might:
    - Hear Kaelin’s natural voice and the raspy voice as distinct sources.
    - See a spectral chain running from her shadow toward Isla or the Obelisk.
    - Force the Queen to speak a single sentence in her own voice.
    - Interrupt the prophetic verse before its magical cadence completes.
    - Identify whether the speaker is the Queen, the Fey Pool, or some third intelligence.
- Cost or danger: The bell suppresses every magically transmitted voice nearby—including warnings, protective enchantments, and beneficial telepathy. After it rings, its bearer cannot speak above a whisper for an hour. If rung three times in the same place, it silences one supernatural voice permanently—but there is no guarantee which voice it chooses.
- Kalem’s complication**:** The bell was taken from a dead cult courier. Jareth would recognize it immediately.

Roleplay haggling with Kalem to obtain the artifacts at a discount

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Kalem’s Price & Negotiation Hooks

Kalem isn’t just going to let these rare and powerful items go cheaply. He offers three paths to obtaining them, each with consequences:

- Gold Payment – If the party has enough gold or valuables, Kalem will sell the items at the stated prices, or possibly at a discount if negotiations are done well
- A Favor Owed – Kalem will lower the cost or even part with one item for free if the party agrees to retrieve something for him.
- Possible Task:
    - Retrieve a black iron key buried beneath the ruined chapel outside Driftmoor.
    - Investigate a smuggler’s stash he hasn’t been able to reach.
    - Find out why some of his contacts have disappeared near the Mistwood Hills.
- A Dark Bargain – Kalem has other interests beyond wealth. He might trade an artifact if a party member signs a contract, offers up a memory, or delivers an unknown parcel to a strange client.

6. The Fey Glade

Deep within the forest lies the Fey Glade—a place of ancient magic, untouched by time. Here, the veil between realms is thin, allowing the whispers of the Feywild to bleed into the mortal world. Unlike the dark, foreboding stretches of the Mistwood, the Fey Glade is alive with an unnatural vibrancy—flowers glow with soft luminescence, the air hums with unseen melodies, and the very earth pulses with a quiet, rhythmic energy, as if breathing in tandem with the land itself.

At the center of the glade, a crystalline spring flows in a perfect circle, its waters unnaturally clear, reflecting not just the sky above, but glimpses of the Feywild itself. Will-o'-wisps flicker along the treetops, guiding or misleading travelers, and the towering silver-barked trees seem to shift subtly when unobserved, their branches curling like watchful sentinels.

The party must roll a Wisdom save or be drawn to the pool, gazing into it with their spirits being helplessly drawn in. While they gaze into the pool they may learn of the Legends & Rumors, see into their past or future actions or meet the Hidden Guardian.

Legends & Rumors

1. The Glade is a Place of Oaths – It is said that any promise sworn in the Fey Glade is bound by magic—a broken vow may call forth the wrath of unseen fey.
2. The Pool of Echoes – Those who gaze into the spring may see glimpses of their past, present, or possible futures, but they must beware—for the pool does not lie, but neither does it show the whole truth.
3. A Hidden Guardian – An ancient fey entity—perhaps a dryad, eladrin, or trickster spirit—watches over the glade, intervening when mortals disrespect its sanctity.
4. The Path to Elsewhere – On certain nights, under the right alignment of stars, the glade becomes a crossing point, allowing passage into the Feywild—for those bold or foolish enough to step through.
5. Cursed to Wander – Some say if one disrespects the glade, they may be cursed to walk in circles forever, never finding the way out until they offer something of true worth to the fey.

How the Party Might Use the Fey Glade

- A Place to Seek Visions – The Pool of Echoes may grant the adventurers a vision of the Queen of Chains' past or future, helping them understand her origins.
- A Site for a Powerful Ritual – If the party must rebind the Queen, the Fey Glade's inherent magic could be the key to sealing her away permanently.
- A Potential Ally or Threat – If a Fey Guardian resides here, it might aid the party in stopping the Queen—or demand a high price for its help.
- A Gateway to the Feywild – If the Queen's influence spreads, the Fey might intervene, seeing her as a threat to the balance between worlds.

7. The Background

Six paths exit the glade. Which will the party take?

The ritual partially succeeded

The cultists believed Isla was a sacrifice, but she was actually being used as a living conduit. The Shadowbeast's tendril joined three things:

Isla → the Obelisk → the Queen of Chains

Raleth intended to carve a sigil beneath her, completing the connection and turning Isla into the mortal anchor through which the Queen could enter the world.

The party stopped the ritual before completion. Consequently:

- The Queen was not freed.
- Isla survived.
- Some of the Obelisk's chains were permanently weakened.

- The unfinished sigil was impressed upon Isla rather than carved into the altar.
- The connection between Isla and the Queen remained dormant.

Isla is therefore not literally the Queen's prison. She bears the unfinished portion of the unlocking ritual:

The child bears the lock.

Why Kaelin is the key

Kaelin participated in the interruption and later looked into the Fey Pool. The Pool showed her both past and future—not merely memories and predictions, but alternate possibilities.

Among the futures it contained was the outcome in which the ritual succeeded.

When Kaelin composed and performed "The Fey Glade," she unknowingly gave musical form to the Pool's magic. Her song recreated the emotional and magical pattern of her encounter with it. For a moment, Kaelin became capable of voicing something the Pool remembered but reality had rejected:

The pool remembers what never came to be.

The melody is the missing completion of the ritual. Raleth used an ancient chant; Kaelin has unknowingly translated its underlying magical pattern into music.

That makes her:

The singer who bears the key.

The key is not Kaelin herself so much as a specific sequence of notes embedded within her song. She does not consciously know the melody and may be unable to reproduce it deliberately. Something else completed it through her.

Why it happened now

Several plausible triggers could have activated the connection:

- **Isla reached a significant age.** The interrupted sigil has begun maturing with her.
- **A chain on the Obelisk finally broke.** The Queen now has enough influence to reach Kaelin.
- **Kaelin performed both connected stories.** Singing first about the Pool and then the kidnapping joined two halves of the event in public memory.
- **Someone in the audience carried an Obelisk fragment.** Its proximity completed the resonance.
- **The rough-looking man deliberately triggered it.** He carried a ritual token, whispered the lost response to Kaelin's melody, or performed a subtle gesture at the proper moment.
- **The anniversary arrived.** The performance occurred at the same hour or lunar alignment as the original ritual.

The best version may combine the anniversary with the rough man's presence. He came expecting something to happen but did not expect it to be so powerful.

The visions

The visions were not random. They showed the two possible resolutions of the interrupted ritual.

Older Isla beside the Fey Pool

This is the future in which Isla survives long enough to understand and control the mark. She eventually goes to the Pool because it is the only place where the unrealized portion of the ritual can be separated from her.

She may become:

- Guardian of the Pool
- The next keeper of the Queen's prison
- A seer able to perceive discarded futures
- The only person capable of repairing the broken chains
- A willing sacrifice who must choose whether to restore the seal

The vision should feel hopeful but ambiguous. Older Isla is alive—but perhaps unable to leave the Pool.

The Obelisk and the Queen breaking free

This is the future in which the dormant ritual is completed. Isla becomes the Queen's anchor, and Kaelin's song becomes the activating key.

The witnesses may have seen different details:

- Isla standing before the Obelisk with the incomplete sigil burning on her skin
- Kaelin singing while unaware of what her voice is doing
- The spectral chains shattering in time with the song
- Raleth—or something wearing Raleth's body—finishing the sigil
- The Queen stepping through Isla's shadow

The violet flames

The violet fire is the Queen's black flame altered by the Fey Pool.

At the altar, Raleth's dagger burned black. The Pool's influence is shimmering and multicolored. When the two magics overlap, ordinary flame turns violet.

That gives violet fire a precise meaning in the campaign:

It appears when an unrealized future involving the Queen is pressing against the present.

Violet flame could therefore become a useful warning sign rather than simple atmosphere. It may reveal:

- People touched by the interrupted ritual
- Obelisk fragments
- Places where alternate outcomes remain possible
- Lies concerning Isla or the ritual
- Moments when the Queen is observing through someone

The rough-looking man

The most satisfying identity is **Brother Jareth**.

He fled the ritual when the party attacked—or survived and disappeared during the fighting. Years later, he came to the Broken Lantern because he heard Kaelin was performing the song of the Fey Glade.

During the performance, he recognized the cadence of Raleth's ritual chant beneath Kaelin's melody.

He leaves quickly because he now understands three terrible facts:

1. The ritual was never truly stopped.
2. Isla still carries its unfinished sigil.
3. Kaelin can complete it.

Jareth does not have to remain a villain. His reluctance during the ritual makes him an excellent compromised witness. He may have spent years hiding from both the cult and his guilt.

Possible motives for leaving:

- He is rushing to warn the Haversteads.
- He believes Isla must be killed before the ritual can be completed.
- He is going to retrieve Raleth's ritual notes.
- He fears the Queen recognized him through Kaelin.
- He has been ordered to report any manifestation of violet fire.
- He knows the final verse has a second stanza and wants to prevent Kaelin from learning it.

What the party can discover

Following Jareth could reveal the underlying story gradually:

- The ceremonial dagger never carved the altar because the intended sigil appeared faintly on Isla instead.
- Jareth remembers the cult's chant, but its final cadence is missing.
- Kaelin's four unnatural lines fit that missing cadence exactly.
- The violet flames lean toward either Kaelin or an Obelisk fragment.
- Isla has been drawing a round pool surrounded by broken chains.
- Isla sometimes describes memories of growing up that have not happened.
- Reflections show Isla several years older.
- When Kaelin hums the melody, Isla answers with a tune nobody taught her.
- The Queen cannot presently speak through Isla—but she can hear through her.

The danger

The party should not simply need to keep Kaelin from singing. That would make the mystery too easy. The key melody should also be capable of locking the prison again.

The same song can complete either of two patterns:

- Sung according to Raleth's ritual, it breaks the remaining chains.
- Sung according to the Fey Pool's counter-melody, it restores or transforms the seal.

Kaelin therefore becomes essential, not merely hazardous. Isla bears the unfinished lock; Kaelin bears both the key and the choice of which way it turns.

The central dilemma becomes:

To save Isla from carrying the seal forever, they may have to open the lock briefly—and trust Kaelin to close it before the Queen passes through.

The Fey Pool marked Kaelin first because it showed her a future that had not yet occurred: Isla at the altar, the interrupted ritual, and perhaps the Queen's eventual escape. Kaelin experienced those images only as indistinct glimpses and consciously remembered a pleasurable vision of her own old age. The Pool retained everything else beneath conscious recall.

Then the party disrupted the ritual. Kaelin's presence connected the Pool's unrealized future to the event occurring in reality. Isla emerged bearing the incomplete lock, while Kaelin—already carrying the Pool's memory of the ritual—became the key.

So:

The Pool foresaw the ritual.
Isla survived it.
Kaelin connected the prophecy to reality.
Jareth knows how the ritual was meant to end.

Jareth now becomes the only surviving person likely to understand both the ritual's structure and what was left incomplete. He knows:

- What Raleth intended to carve beneath Isla
- Which chains disintegrated before the interruption
- The words and cadence of the unfinished chant
- Whether Raleth survived, died, or became a vessel
- Why an infant was required
- What happens when Isla reaches the ritual's intended age or condition
- How the rite might be reversed

His reluctance at the altar also gives him excellent dramatic ambiguity. He participated in something unforgivable, but his faltering chant may have helped the party interrupt it. He could be remorseful, self-serving, terrified, or all three.

A strong next sequence would be:

1. **Jareth flees the Broken Lantern.** If followed, he attempts to lose the party rather than fight.
2. **He carries a fragment of black chain.** It became warm when Kaelin's voice changed and now gives off faint violet sparks.
3. **He recognizes Kaelin.** He remembers her from the altar and calls her "the Witness" or "the Singer."
4. **He asks whether Isla is still alive.** His relief is immediately followed by terror.
5. **He reveals that the ritual did not fail—it paused.**
6. **He warns them never to let Kaelin sing the four lines near Isla.**
7. **Then Isla begins singing the melody somewhere else.**

Jareth's key line could be:

"We thought the child was the sacrifice. Raleth knew better. She was the doorway. You tore her from the altar before it opened—but doorways remember the hand upon the latch."

And when he realizes what Kaelin carries:

"The chant had no ending. Not until tonight. Whatever spoke through you just gave it one."

That establishes him as critical without making him immediately trustworthy. The party needs his knowledge, while Jareth needs their protection from the remaining cult—and possibly from the Queen, who now knows that the reluctant witness survived.